UNDER THE ARCADIAN SKY

Written by

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BLACK.

UNSEEN NARRATOR (V.O.)
I know it was just a dream...but it felt different.

CUT TO:

EXT. TERRESTRIAL PARADISE - DAY

As the voiceover continues, we see shots of a terrestrial paradise. There are beautiful shots of trees, forests, meadows, waterfalls, etc.

UNSEEN NARATOR (V.O. - CONT'D)
I could tell that I was still on earth, but it was very far in the future and I felt as if everyone had left long ago. I felt the weight of centuries on my soul, but I wasn't old. I looked younger than I am now. It's like I'm trying to remember the time before...

CUT TO:

INT. WILLIAMSBURG BAR, PRESENT DAY - NIGHT

We cut from the shots of the terrestrial paradise to the interior of a bar in Williamsburg, Brooklyn. The narrator is revealed to be SARAH FIORE. She is 39 years old. She sits at a table with her coworker ROBERT D'ANGIOLO. In contrast to the sound of her voice in the V.O. Sarah's voice now sounds grounded in reality, like someone just sitting and talking in a bar.

SARAH
...the time we're in now, but it's like the memories belong to another person.

ROBERT
It was just a dream Sarah.

SARAH
Yes, I know that Robert...that was the first thing I said...but it felt like it could have really meant something to me.

ROBERT
You think everything means something.

SARAH
When? I've never said anything like this before to anyone. I don't believe in anything.

ROBERT
You're just very bored, and you're a dreamer.

SARAH
I'm a dreamer? Have you ever met me?

ROBERT
I've worked in an office with you for a year and a half, trust me, you're a dreamer.

SARAH
Define "dreamer".

ROBERT
You think things could be different than they are.

SARAH
That's called an idealist, Robert.

ROBERT
Same difference.

Sarah takes a gulp of her IPA.

SARAH
Did you talk to Lauren?

ROBERT
About the layoffs?

SARAH
No, about her hemorrhoids. Yes! About the layoffs.

ROBERT
Probably a few people from engineering in the fall.

SARAH
Who?

ROBERT
I don't know, I didn't ask and I don't care.

SARAH
You don't care? You guys have a new baby.

ROBERT
If it's gonna happen, it's gonna happen, and honestly Tracey makes more money than me anyway.

Beat.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Look, I wouldn't worry about if I were you.

SARAH
You think they'll keep me?

ROBERT
No, almost certainly not, Steve hates you. I just don't think you should worry about something you can't do anything about.

Sarah sighs.

SARAH
What the fuck am gonna do?

ROBERT
Just do freelancing or something. You'll be fine.

SARAH
Right, I guess it turns out my destiny really is to be "fine".

ROBERT
Look, I've gotta get home. I'll see you tomorrow.

SARAH
(Dejected)
See ya.

Robert gets up from the table, walks out of the bar and heads home to his wife and new baby leaving Sarah alone at the table.

After he walks out, Sarah leans back in her chair to use the window as a mirror. She unravels her pony tail and lets her hair down. Satisfied with her appearance, she goes up to the bar, orders a drink and does her best to make herself approachable.

After several minutes a cute guy starts to make his way towards Sarah and she gets excited. But right when he gets to Sarah he makes a head gesture to someone directly behind her and walks right past her.

A dejected Sarah signals to the bartender for another drink.

EXT. WILLIAMSBURG PIER, EAST RIVER - NIGHT

Sarah walks down the Williamsburg Pier north of the bridge and stares at the black water for a moment before she lights a cigarette and looks up at the sky to see a handful of visible stars that are bright enough to break through the city's light pollution. Sarah takes a drag of her cigarette as she takes in the few visible stars with as much hope as she can muster.

Sarah is a dreamer.

INT. SARAH'S BATHROOM - MORNING

Sarah enters the bathroom in her apartment to do her monthly purge of grey hairs. She examines her hairline to identify the targets.

We watch in quick succession as Sarah plucks out several grey hairs on either side of her head.

CUT TO:

Pluck number one.

CUT TO:

Pluck number two.

CUT TO:

Pluck number three.

After she plucks out the last hair Sarah briefly smiles at herself in the mirror with her small victory over aging. Her smile disappears when she remembers that she's fighting a losing battle and that sometime sooner or later the tweezer won't cut it.

INT. OFFICE, DUMBO - DAY

Sarah's boss STEVE X, early 50's, speaks in front of about forty employees in a brightly lit tech office in the DUMBO neighborhood of Brooklyn. Sarah, a minute or two late for the meeting, quietly walks through the open doorway and slowly makes her way across the back of the crowd.

We follow her as she slowly weaves between the crowd, but we never lose sight of her and she never lets a gaze drift from the front of the room.

STEVE
…so I want all the PMs to email me about that before the end of the day. But the real reason I called an all-hands is because corporate sent over a pretty unusual task for the entire department. Since the Turing test was rendered moot by LLMs, the entire industry has been using unreliable benchmarks, and we need an entirely new way to measure these systems as they become more intelligent. So what I need to day today is ideas I don’t want to go I need out of the box ideas I need orthogonal thinking

Sarah rolls her eyes at at Steve’s use of the word “orthogonal”

STEVE (CONT'D)
I don’t care how crazy or weird your ideas is are, just email me the task by the end of the day

The all hands meeting disperses. Everyone heads to their workstations and conference rooms. Sarah hangs back for a moment, staring at the floor, contemplating her assigned task.

INT - OFFICE - LATER THAT DAY

Sarah sits at her workstation, eating a yogurt and playfully swinging back and forth in her chair. She writes something in her notebook, looks out the window and eats a spoonful of yogurt. After a beat Sarah thinks of an idea, with a calm excitement, she swivels her chair chair to her workstation, spoon in mouth, and begins to type up an email.

INT - OFFICE - DUSK

Sarah confidently walks into Steve’s office.

SARAH
Hey, did you get a chance to read my idea.

STEVE
Yeah Sarah um I don’t think you understood what I was asking the team. I’m looking for an objective measure of intelligence. I didn't really understand what you’re email said about using my request as the answer.

SARAH
I mean we could simply just ask newly released models to think outside of the box, just like you asked.

STEVE
Can you add a few more sentences to that.

Sarah excitedly sits down in the chair in front of Steve’s desk.

SARAH
Okay so it’s not just a simple prompt, we can create a series of complicated prompts that iterate over an array of very specific prompts with very specific questions.

STEVE
What kinds of questions?

SARAH
The most vexing questions we have, like, what do we do about climate change, poverty, whatever, but we build into the prompt that we specifically want out of the box thinking. If you ask it it to come up with solutions that no human could come up with.

STEVE
Then what?

SARAH
(with excitement)
Then we wait.

STEVE
Wait for what?

SARAH
Just wait until we get some interesting answers.

Steve stares at Sarah with curiosity.

SARAH (CONT'D)
Steve we can make the prompts as specific or broad as we like and if these solutions are as powerful as we anticipate, then there's no way using these prompts won't generate interesting ideas.

STEVE
You know that I meant for you to come up with benchmarks tied to objective measurements, how are we going to evaluate prompt responses that are inherently subjective?

SARAH
I can build a leaderboard with up/down votes.

Steve ponders for a moment.

STEVE
Okay.

SARAH
Okay?

STEVE
(smiling)
No harm in trying. I'll have Alice send you the API keys.

Sarah smiles.

SARAH
Awesome.

STEVE
Right, awesome. I'll see you tomorrow.

Sarah walks out of Steve's office, trying her best to hide her excitement.

INT. OFFICE - DAY

We see a relatively short montage of Sarah working on the web app. We see her writing code and testing her app, always eating something different each time we see her working.

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

At last Sarah has finished the web app and starts testing with a prompt asking for advice about preventing global pandemics.

The response is a generic answer representing a combination of information from the WHO and the CDC.

Sarah frowns.

She inputs a second prompt asking about asteroid impact prevention, it returns a response that's basically an amalgamation of ideas you could find on Wikipedia.

Sarah leans back in her chair, sucking on her lollipop, and stares at the ceiling in frustration.

SARAH
Dammit.

Several Months Later:

INT. OFFICE - DAY

Sarah sits at her desk, eating a burrito bowl watching some ridiculous video on YouTube, when her coworker X comes up to her workstation.

X
Hey.

SARAH
What's up?

X
Did you get the email from Alice?

SARAH
(smiling)
I've gotten many emails from Sarah.

X
(smiling)
You should actually read this one.

As X walks away she opens her Gmail to find a new model was released by X.

Sarah opens her web app, inputs the new API key and looks through her collection of prewritten prompts. She chooses “smartphone addiction” and an auto generated prompt gets run against the new model.

A five paragraph response is quickly generated by the new model. Sarah reads through it and it’s relatively generic except for one sentence that catches her eye.

“Take into account the level of At this point of market saturation, practical utility and deeply entrenched daily use, the most practical solution at this point would be a secondary device that would help modulate phone use.”

Before Sarah has any time to contemplate, she receives an email from HR. She has been let go.

INT. STEVE’S OFFICE - DAY

Sarah storms into Steve’s office, furious.

SARAH
You don’t even have the fucking balls to fire me in person.

STEVE
Sarah, relax, I didn’t fire anyone. HR has been planning layoffs for months now. It has nothing to do with performance, the entire department is being downsized.

SARAH
It has nothing to do with performance?

STEVE
No.

SARAH
Then how were the layoffs determined?

Beat.

STEVE
Sarah you’re taking this way too personally. You’re a great programmer. You’ll get another job and I’ll write you a recommendation if you need.

SARAH
Okay, Steve, write me a reference letter and then go ahead and shove it up your ass.

As Sarah walks out of the office Steve returns to the work on his desk.

STEVE
Goodbye, Sarah.

INT. WILLIAMSBURG BAR - NIGHT

In the same bar as the first scene. We see Sarah at the bar drinking alone. She is not at the bar to attract suitors, she is drinking for a single purpose...to get wasted.

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Sarah drunkenly enters her apartment, drops her keys and forgets to lock her apartment. She staggers down the hallway, makes it to the kitchen, trips and falls and hits the crown of her head on the corner of her wall.

CUT TO BLACK:

Sarah awakens back in The Dream. This time the dream is much more vivid. Sarah is there in her younger body and it's night time but it's unlike any physical nighttime Sarah has ever seen before. It's somehow dusk on all sides but as Sarah looks up at the center of the sky she sees what looks like the dead of night. There are thousands of stars visible along with a full moon. A physical impossibility. Sarah explores the landscape like a young girl looking at everything, absorbing anything she sees into her soul. Sarah spots a bunch of flowers in the ground and kneels down to pick one up. She examines it with intense curiosity. The color of the flower is a beautiful mixture of pink and purple. While looking at the flower a single pedal falls off gently falls to the ground and the second it hits the ground… BANG.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - LATE NIGHT

Sarah awakens on the floor of her kitchen in the middle of the night. She takes a second to realize where she is. She is face down in a small puddle of blood, but at first she can't figure out where it came from. Did it come from her mouth? Did she smash her teeth? She realizes that it's coming from the gushing cut behind her forehead. She goes to the bathroom, turns on the light and immediately needs stitches.

INT. HOSPITAL - EARLY MORNING

We see Sarah getting stitches from a nurse in the ER. Her eyes are shut, as the nurse stitches the gash right above her hairline.

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - MORNING

Sarah arrives back in her apartment, takes her sneakers off, walks to the bedroom, lands on her bed and immediately falls asleep.

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - DUSK

Sarah slowly awakens. She stretches, yawns and feels amazed at how much better she feels than when she fell asleep.

INT. SARAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Sarah sits down at her computer with a cup of green tea. She opens up the AI voice model on her workstation.

"I need some help designing and building a wearable device connected to an iPhone application, for some context, I have extensive experience designing and building software but I've never built any hardware before so I'm gonna need you to take me step by step through using CAD software to design the wearable, what components I will need and where to order them and how to use a soldering iron to put it together."

AI voice response:

"Sure, I can help you do all of those things. Tell me more about the wearable you would like to design and build and we can get into the specifics."

Sarah smiles and takes a sip of her tea.

Over several days we see Sarah using CAD software to design the enclosure of the wearable and receiving several packages. We see Sarah unpacking and opening up the soldering iron on her desk. At her workstation wearing safety goggles Sarah solders together the components she ordered using the LLM for guidance. She puts together the components and the enclosure she had 3D printed. Sarah stares at it.

The final enclosure is a tiny 3D printed plastic box sitting on her desk. Purpose still unknown.

Sarah pairs the homemade device to the complementary app she built. She then exits the app and begins playing with her phone, opening different apps and putting her phone on and off several times.

At last she opens her phone to look at the time and the little plastic box on her desk vibrates.

Sarah smiles.